

"The magic happens only when the artist serves with love and the listener receives with the same spirit."

SULTAN OF STRING

By exerting a fundamental influence on global musical tastes, the itinerant maestro has made Indian culture fashionable

■ By S. Kalidas

Each epoch and all lands have their individual greats whose contributions to their country's culture win for them a place in history. Some transcend even that lofty bar to influence all times across all lands and all cultures. For no one so fundamentally influenced the world's understanding of music—and by extension culture itself—as did this frail Bengali Brahmin from Varanasi. As the avant garde American composer Philip Glass unambiguously puts it: "I can say without hesitation or exaggeration that Ravi Shankar is the godfather, the mother and the father of what is called the world music movement today."

In this sense, Shankar's influence and contribution go far beyond that of his other great Indian contemporaries like, say, a Satyajit Ray or a Maharishi Mahesh Yogi. Both Ray

and the much-revered Yogi left a deep and wide-ranging impact through their works. But their legacy did not quite change global attitudes towards filmmaking or spirituality as completely as Shankar's did on the music scene. Even the most conservative of Western composers today cannot claim to be untouched by or unaware of the contribution of Ravi Shankar. More significantly, by exerting such a fundamental influence on global musical tastes, he has made Indian culture itself acceptable and better understood all over the world. He is, after Mahatma Gandhi, the second truly global icon to emerge from 20th century India.

But Shankar's greatness does not lie fettered to his global success alone. From the first stroke of the introductory alaap to the last climax of his thundering jhaala, his model for a classical music concert has in his life-

time become the norm for not only sitar players but for all Indian instrumentalists whether they play the sarod, the flute or the santoor. With a number of vocal compositions, and several vocalists as his students, he has left his mark on the nation's music scene too. Despite his detractors in India, he remains even at 88, the best example of the most orthodox exponent of the raga and the tala, if not the sitar itself. And what is truly amazing is that after all his many illnesses and advanced age, he still graces the concert platform. Just to see him strum a single note is revelation, to hear him play a full piece is sheer bliss.

The author is a senior journalist

Ravi Shankar

Sitarist 1920

Q: For which soundtrack was he nominated for an Academy award?

A: For *Gandhi*, in 1982

Q: He is the disciple of which famous musician?

A: Baba Allaudin Khan, whose daughter Annapurna Devi, he married

Q: For which term was he nominated to the Rajya Sabha?

A: 1986-92

